

BASIC SIGHT-SINGING AND EAR TRAINING FOR CHURCH SINGERS

UNIT 2.2

PITCH

BASIC DEFINITIONS:

INTERVALS AND PITCH PATTERNS



INTERVALS IN THE DO-FA TETRACHORD

The “distance” between two adjacent pitches is called an **interval**. In other words, an interval expresses the relationship between two adjacent pitches. The knowledge of intervals and the ability to reproduce them vocally on demand is crucial to the ability to sight-sing.

Intervals can be **ascending** or **descending**.

The DO-FA Tetrachord contains the following intervals:

DO - RE	Whole step or Major Second (i.e., two adjacent notes)
RE - MI	Whole step or Major Second (i.e., two adjacent notes)
MI - FA	Half step or Minor Second (also two adjacent notes, but a smaller distance apart)

DO - MI	Major Third (formed by stepping three adjacent notes — two whole steps in a row)
RE - FA	Minor Third (formed by stepping three adjacent notes — a whole step and a half step)
DO - FA	Perfect Fourth (formed by stepping four adjacent notes — two whole steps and a half step)

In the “moveable-DO” system, these definitions remain true **no matter** what starting pitch is defined as “DO.” In other words, “DO - MI” will **always** be a Major Third, by definition. “RE - FA” will always be a Minor Third, by definition.

Looking at it from the opposite direction, one can always sing a Major Third by singing “DO - MI” (or descending — “MI - DO”); one can always sing a Minor Third by singing “RE - FA” (or descending — “FA - RE”).

As you practice the intervals in the DO-FA Tetrachord, try to relate and coordinate the movements of the voice to the hand signs below.



Do



Re



Mi



Fa



Sol



La



Ti



Do

KODALY HAND SIGNS

PITCH PATTERNS IN ORTHODOX CHANT

Being able to recognize and sing intervals is very important in Orthodox liturgical chant, since a lot of it is based on repeated **pitch patterns** (sometimes referred to as “formulas”), collectively known as the Eight Tones (in Greek — Octoechos, from *okto* “eight” and *echos* “sound, mode”).

Using only the four notes of the DO-FA Tetrachord, we can sing several well-known melodies of the Eight Tones.

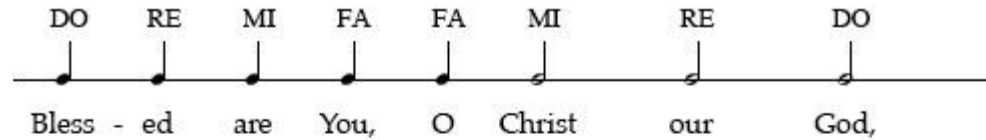
Using the “BEST PRACTICES” we introduced earlier (Unit 1.1, Slide 10)

1. Set the pulse and read through the rhythm FIRST!
2. Analyze the Sol-Fa syllables in each line. Note similarities and differences.
3. Keeping the pulse, read the Sol-Fa syllables, trying to hear the pitch in your mind.
4. Sing on the Sol-Fa syllables, keeping a steady pulse.

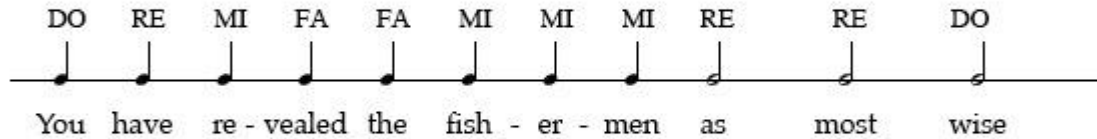
TROPARION OF PENTECOST

TONE 8 (COMMON CHANT)

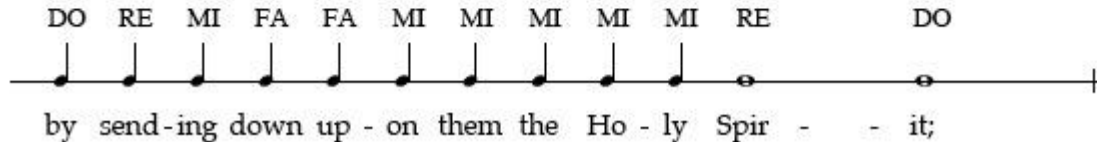
Phrase 1 →



Phrase 2 →



Phrase 3 →

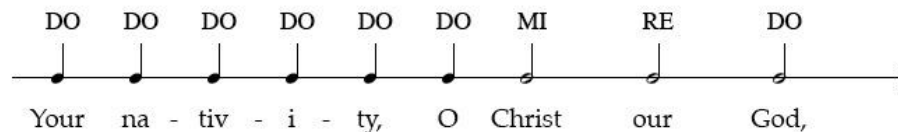


Note that there are three **phrases**, each of which uses the Sol-Fa syllables DO, RE, MI, FA, in the same identical order. If you recognize this as a **repeated pattern**, this will help you sight-read this Tone 8 Troparion (and all subsequent ones).

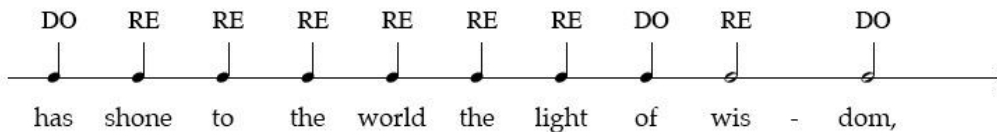
TROPARION OF THE NATIVITY OF CHRIST

TONE 4 (ABBR. GREEK CHANT)

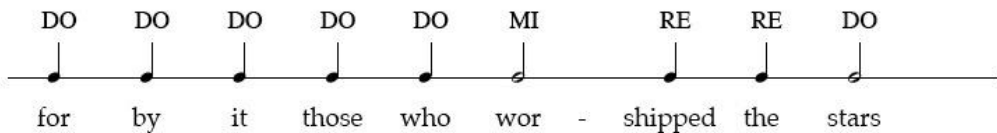
Phrase A →



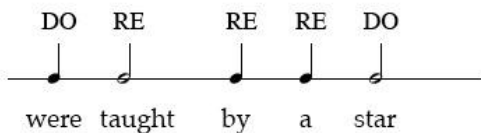
Phrase B →



Phrase A →



Phrase B →

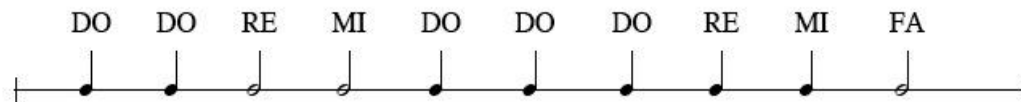


Here the pattern is two phrases, A and B: even though the number of syllables is different in each phrase, each phrase A and each phrase B uses the same Sol-Fa pitches.

RESURRECTIONAL TROPARION

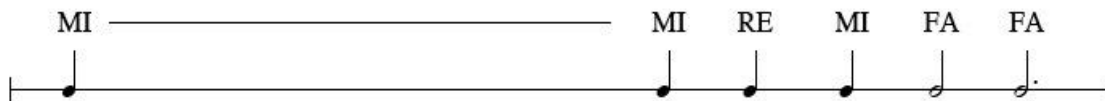
TONE 1 (COMMON CHANT)

Phrase 1 →



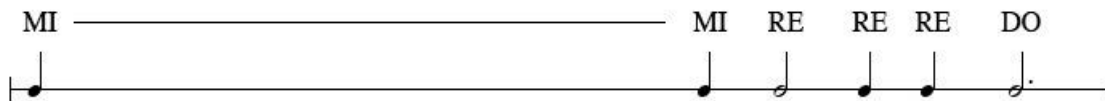
When the stone__ had been sealed by the Jews,

Phrase 2a →



while the soldiers were guarding Your most pure bod - y,

Phrase 2b →



You rose on the third day, O Savior, granting life to the world.

Here we have three **different** phrases, all built out of the notes of the DO-FA Tetrachord—DO, RE, MI, FA. In the passages marked by a straight line, the words are all repeated on the same note (MI), called the **reciting pitch**. The remainder of this Troparion is built using the same musical patterns of notes and phrases, as are other Troparia in Tone 1.

You are now ready to master intervals in the
DO-FA TETRACHORD

Please proceed to
PITCH EXERCISES 2.1, 2.2, & 2.3

The instructions for these exercises are
contained in the video files and should be
self-explanatory.

